

THE LITTLE BEAR

Ursa Minor



SIZE RANKING 56

BRIGHTEST STAR
Polaris (α) 2.0GENITIVE
Ursae Minoris

ABBREVIATION UMi

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM
May–JulyFULLY VISIBLE
90°N–0°

Ursa Minor is an ancient Greek constellation, which is said to represent Ida, one of the nymphs who nursed the god Zeus when he was an infant (see panel, right). Ursa Minor contains the north celestial pole and also its nearest naked-eye star, Polaris or Alpha (α) Ursae Minoris (see pp.278–279), which is currently less than 1 degree from the north celestial pole. The distance between them is steadily decreasing due to precession (see p.64). They will come closest around 2100, when the separation will be about 0.5°.

The main stars of Ursa Minor form a shape known as the Little Dipper, reminiscent of the larger and brighter Big Dipper in Ursa Major, although its handle curves in the opposite direction. The two brightest stars in the bowl of the Little Dipper, Beta (β) and Gamma (γ) Ursae Minoris, are popularly known as the Guardians of the Pole.



THE NORTH POLE STAR

This image of Polaris was taken through a telescope, but the star is clearly visible with the naked eye. Images taken by the Hubble Space Telescope have revealed that Polaris has a companion not visible from Earth.

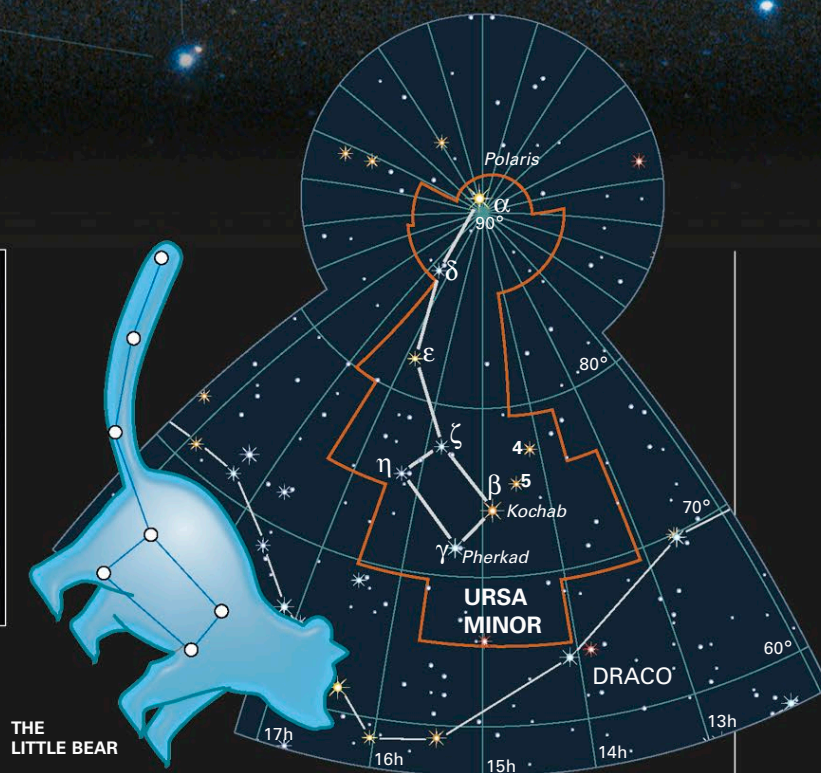
SPECIFIC FEATURES

Polaris, the north Pole Star, is a creamy white supergiant and a Cepheid variable (see p.282), but its brightness changes are too slight to be noticeable to the naked eye. With a telescope, an unrelated 8th-magnitude star can be seen nearby.

Two stars in the bowl of the Little Dipper—Gamma and Eta Ursae Minoris—are both wide doubles. Gamma is the brighter of the two, at magnitude 3.0, and its 5th-magnitude companion, 11 Ursae Minoris, can be seen with the naked eye or binoculars. Eta, at magnitude 5.0, can also be seen with the naked eye. It has a partner of magnitude 5.5, 19 Ursae Minoris; both stars are easily visible with binoculars. Each of the component stars in both Gamma and Eta lie at different distances from the Earth and are thus unrelated.

LONG-TAILED BEAR

The tail of the Little Bear curves away from the north Pole Star, Polaris (upper left). Unlike real bears, the celestial bears Ursa Minor and Ursa Major both have long tails.



THE LITTLE BEAR

MYTHS AND STORIES

NURSING NYMPHS

According to Greek mythology, at his birth, the infant Zeus was hidden from his murderous father, Cronus, and taken to a cave on the island of Crete, where he was nursed by two nymphs, usually named as Adrastea and Ida. In gratitude, Zeus later placed the nymphs in the sky as the Great Bear and the Little Bear, respectively.

THE PROTECTED CHILD

The infant Zeus is cared for by nymphs and shepherds, in the *Feeding of Jupiter* by the French artist Nicolas Poussin.

